

East Austin Neighborhood Guide: 78702 and 78721 Decoded

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THE SHORT ANSWER

East Austin's 78702 zip code is Austin's most culturally dynamic urban market, with single-family homes from \$500K to \$900K and strong STR income potential. 78721, slightly farther east, offers more affordability at \$400K-\$700K. School zones within Austin ISD vary significantly — verify at the address level before making an offer.

No part of Austin has changed faster over the past fifteen years than the neighborhoods east of I-35. And no part of Austin is more frequently misunderstood by buyers arriving with impressions formed five years too late.

East Austin in 2026 is a maturing urban market — still dynamic, still culturally distinct, still one of the most interesting neighborhoods in the city to live in — but one that requires honest assessment of what you are buying, where exactly it is, and what the realistic outlook looks like from that specific address.

The Two Zip Codes and How They Differ

East Austin encompasses two primary residential zip codes: 78702 and 78721. They are adjacent, share a cultural identity, and are frequently treated as interchangeable. They are not. 78702 is the core — it includes East 6th Street, Chestnut, Cherrywood, Holly, French Place, and the MLK corridor. The cultural infrastructure that defines East Austin — Franklin Barbecue, the bars on East 6th, Cenote, Veracruz All Natural — is concentrated here. 78721 stretches farther east (Govalle, Johnston Terrace) and is meaningfully less expensive with a somewhat different buyer profile.

What You Can Buy and What It Costs

In 78702, single-family homes start around \$500,000 for older structures in original condition. Well-maintained or updated original bungalows range from \$600,000 to \$800,000. Newer construction single-family homes range from \$750,000 to \$950,000. Attached townhomes range

from \$450,000 to \$700,000. 78721 runs 15 to 25% less expensive than 78702 across comparable product types, with single-family homes starting around \$400,000.

The Lifestyle That East Austin Actually Offers

East Austin's residential appeal is rooted in cultural density. Franklin Barbecue, Veracruz All Natural, La Barbecue, Dai Due, Cenote, and dozens of nationally recognized food destinations are in or adjacent to East Austin. The East 6th Street bar corridor is walkable from most of the neighborhood. The density of independent coffee shops, creative businesses, and cultural venues is unmatched elsewhere in Austin.

The trade-off is residential character. East Austin is not quiet. East 6th Street generates noise that affects immediately surrounding blocks late into weekend nights. Construction activity has been continuous for over a decade. The neighborhood is still evolving — which means the block you buy on today may look meaningfully different in five years.

School Zones in East Austin: Significant Variation

East Austin falls entirely within Austin ISD, and school quality within AISD varies more here than in most other Austin residential areas. Elementary schools include Metz Elementary, Campbell Elementary, Govalle Elementary, and others depending on specific address. None of the East Austin elementary schools currently carry the same level of market-driving demand as Casis Elementary in Tarrytown or the Eanes ISD schools in Westlake. Buyers with school-age children should verify the specific school assignment at the address level using the AISD school finder.

East Austin as a Short-Term Rental Market

East Austin is one of Austin's strongest short-term rental markets — a natural consequence of its proximity to downtown, cultural appeal, and walkability to venues that draw SXSW, ACL, and conference travelers. Buyers considering STR use should verify license availability for the specific address and understand Austin's STR licensing requirements, which distinguish between owner-occupied and investor-owned properties.

What Is Happening to East Austin: Development and Its Implications

East Austin has been one of the most actively developed residential areas in Austin for over a decade. Before making an offer on any East Austin property, buyers should look up current zoning and any pending permits for adjacent and nearby parcels using the City of Austin's development portal.

Who Buys in East Austin

East Austin attracts a distinctly different buyer profile than Tarrytown or Westlake Hills. The most common buyer is a professional in their late 20s to early 40s — often single or in a couple without school-age children — who values walkability, cultural access, and urban living over lot size and school zone. Investors purchasing for STR income or long-term appreciation are more concentrated in East Austin than in most other central Austin neighborhoods.

The Long-Term Outlook

The fundamentals that drove East Austin's appreciation — walkability, cultural density, proximity to downtown, and sustained lifestyle demand — remain in place. East Austin is a strong long-term hold for buyers whose lifestyle aligns with what the neighborhood offers and who understand the trade-offs clearly. It is a less obvious choice for buyers seeking school-district security of Tarrytown or Westlake Hills.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Is East Austin a good place to buy a home?

East Austin is an excellent choice for buyers who prioritize walkability, cultural access, and proximity to downtown — and who are comfortable with a neighborhood that continues to evolve. 78702 offers urban living with strong short-term rental income potential. It is a less obvious choice for buyers with school-age children, who should research AISD school assignments carefully at the specific address.

What are home prices in East Austin in 2026?

In 78702 (central East Austin), single-family homes range from approximately \$500,000 for original structures needing updating to \$950,000 for well-finished updated properties and new construction. Townhomes range from \$450,000 to \$700,000. The 78721 zip code is 15-25% less expensive.

What neighborhoods are in East Austin?

East Austin encompasses several distinct sub-neighborhoods. In 78702: Chestnut, Cherrywood, Holly, French Place, and areas along East 6th and East Cesar Chavez. In 78721: Govalle, Johnston Terrace, and neighborhoods approaching the airport corridor.

What are the schools like in East Austin?

East Austin falls entirely within Austin ISD. School assignments vary significantly by address and include Metz, Campbell, Govalle Elementary, and others. Performance ratings vary more widely than in premium school zone neighborhoods like Tarrytown or Westlake Hills. Buyers with school-age children should verify specific assignments using the AISD school finder.

Is East Austin good for short-term rentals (Airbnb)?

East Austin — particularly 78702 — is one of Austin's strongest STR markets due to its proximity to downtown, walkability to SXSW and ACL venues, and lifestyle appeal. Buyers should verify STR license availability at the specific address before purchasing, as Austin's regulations distinguish between owner-occupied and investor-owned properties.